

Latvian ditransitives: Evidence for a low applicative structure *

Gabriel Correa (UMass Amherst)

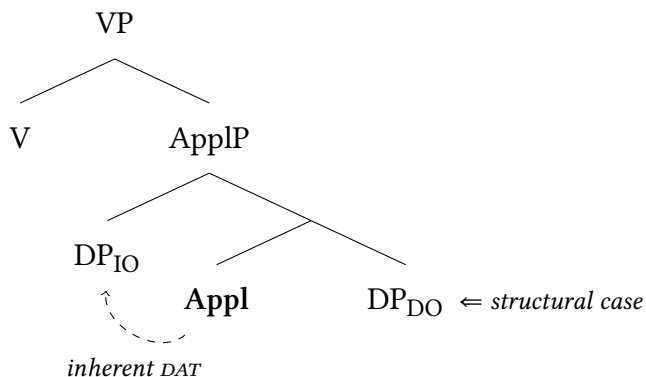
gbcorrea@umass.edu

ECO-5 @ Harvard • March 7, 2026

1 Introduction

In today's talk, I will be putting forth the proposal that Latvian double-object ditransitive constructions are (i) **LOW APPLICATIVES**, in the sense of Pylkkänen (2000, 2002), and (ii) **ASYMMETRIC APPLICATIVES**: the IO and DO arguments display different properties (e.g. McGinnis 1998, 2008).

(1) *Low applicative structure in Latvian ditransitives*



- The DO is merged as the complement of the Appl(icative) head, while the IO merges in Spec, ApplP
- ApplP is selected by the verb and relates two individuals in a transfer of possession relation (see Pylkkänen 2002)
- I suggest that the IO receives both the goal θ -role and INHERENT DATIVE CASE from Appl, while the DO receives structural case elsewhere

* I'm grateful to Kyle Johnson for the invaluable discussion and feedback on an earlier version of this talk when it still had the shape of a term paper. Thank you to the audience at ECO-5 (in special Yiannis Katochoritis) for their insightful comments and suggestions. *HUGE* thanks to Reinis Pauļuks for all the Latvian judgments and other comments on this project!

2 Evidence for low applicative structure

- In §2.1, I will show that unergative verbs cannot have an applied argument in Latvian, which is consistent with the low Appl analysis proposed here
- In §2.2, I will argue that the low Appl analysis correctly predicts the distribution of depictive secondary predicates in Latvian: the indirect object of a ditransitive verb cannot be modified by a depictive

2.1 Transitivity restrictions

Low applicatives care about the valency of the verb: since a low Appl head relates the IO to the DO, it cannot appear in a structure where there is no direct object (Pylkkänen 2002: 23). Therefore, **unergative verbs cannot be applicativized in a low Appl language.**

This prediction is borne out in Latvian: adding an applied object to the unergative verb ‘bake’ is ungrammatical in (2), but it is grammatical with the transitive verb ‘bake’ in (3):

- (2) a. *Es Jānim skrēju ✗ UNERGATIVE
 I.NOM John.DAT ran.1
 Intended: ‘I ran for John.’
- b. Es Jānim uzcepu kūku ✓ TRANSITIVE
 I.NOM John.DAT baked.1 cake.ACC
 ‘I baked John a cake.’

2.1.1 An apparent exception: static verbs?

Pylkkänen (2002: 23) argues that low Appl languages should not be able to applicativize verbs that do not denote a transfer of possession relation, such as static verbs (e.g. ‘hold’)

Latvian, however, does allow a DAT-marked argument with the verb ‘hold’ (3a):

- (3) a. Es Jānim paturēju somu
 I.NOM John.DAT held.1 bag.ACC
 ‘I held John’s bag for him.’
 NOT: ‘I held a bag for John.’
- b. *Es Jānim paturēju tavu somu
 I.NOM John.DAT held.1 your.ACC bag.ACC
 Intended: ‘I held your bag for John.’

- I would like to provisionally suggest that this structure should be better analyzed as a case of POSSESSOR RAISING rather than a canonical low Appl construction: (3a) requires that the bag is owned by John and implies that he benefitted from me holding his bag
- Crucially, note that (3b) is ungrammatical if the owner of the bag is a different individual from the DAT-marked argument – as expressed by the overt possessive determiner *tavu* ‘your.ACC’

Therefore, I conclude that (3a) is not a counterexample to the low Appl analysis for Latvian ditransitives; rather, its properties are suggestive of possessor raising construction: (i) the DAT-marked argument must necessarily be interpreted as the possessor of the ACC object; (ii) an overt possessive determiner is not licensed in this construction (*it remains to be tested whether an overt possessor would be allowed if it is to be interpreted coreferentially with the dative argument*)

2.2 Depictive secondary predication

The second diagnostic for low applicative structure we will apply to Latvian is modification by a DEPICTIVE SECONDARY PREDICATE. Before discussing the Latvian data, I will briefly turn to a discussion of the distribution of depictives in English and low Appl languages in general.

2.2.1 Depictives in low Appl languages

English has both object and subject depictives (4a-b), but neither implicit external arguments of passives nor PP complements can be modified by a depictive (4c-d). Crucially, (4e) shows that depictives cannot modify the IO in a double-object construction in English:

- (4) a. Mary drank the coffee cold . ✓ OBJECT DEPICTIVE
 b. Mary drank the coffee tired . ✓ SUBJECT DEPICTIVE
 c. * The coffee was drunk tired . ✗ IMPLICIT EXTERNAL ARGUMENT
 d. * Mary talked to John tired . ✗ PP COMPLEMENT
 [Scenario: Only John is tired.]
 e. * John told Mary the news drunk . ✗ LOW APPLICATIVE
 [Scenario: John is sober, but Mary is drunk.]

Taking these English facts as a departing point, Pyllkkänen (2002) proposes the correlation in (5) between the properties of depictives in a given language and the height of the Appl head in that language:

- (5) *Restriction on modification by depictives* (Pylkkänen 2002: 31)
 “If a language has an English type depictive secondary predicate, the depictive can modify an applied argument only if the applied argument is high.”

2.2.2 Depictives in Latvian

Fortunately, Latvian does indeed have depictives, which means that we can test whether (5) holds! I present the relevant examples in (6) below:

- Objects and subjects can be modified by a depictive (6a-b), while implicit external arguments of a passive and PP complements cannot (6c-d)
- I thus take it that Latvian depictives can be considered “English-like”, at least for our current purposes

- (6) a. Maija izdzēra kafiju aukstu ✓ OBJECT DEPICTIVE
 Mary.NOM drank.3 coffee.ACC cold.ACC.FSG
 ‘Mary drank the coffee cold.’
- b. Maija izdzēra kafiju piekususi ✓ SUBJECT DEPICTIVE
 Mary.NOM drank.3 coffee.ACC tired.NOM.FSG
 ‘Mary drank the coffee tired.’
- c. *Kafija tika izdzerta piekusi ✗ IMPLICIT EXTERNAL ARGUMENT
 coffee.NOM was.3 drunk.NOM.FSG tired.NOM.MSG
 Intended: ‘The coffee was drunk tired.’
- d. ? Maija runāja ar Jāni piekusušu ? PP COMPLEMENT
 Mary.NOM talked.3 with John.ACC tired.ACC.MSG
 Intended: ‘Mary talked to John tired.’
 [Scenario: Only John is tired.]

Let us now return to ditransitives: the prediction in (5) is indeed borne out in Latvian. The ungrammaticality of (7) shows that a depictive cannot modify the dative argument of a ditransitive verb in Latvian, which is consistent with the low applicative analysis.

- (7) * Jānis pateica Maijai jaunumus piedzērusies ✗ LOW APPLICATIVE
 John.NOM told.3 Mary.DAT news.ACC drunk.DAT.FSG
 Intended: ‘John told Mary the news drunk.’
 [Scenario: John is sober, but Mary is drunk.]

3 DAT-ACC asymmetries in ditransitives

- In §3.1, I will show that Weak Crossover (WCO) violations arise in the ACC-DAT surface configuration, but crucially not in the DAT-ACC configuration. I argue this asymmetry follows straightforwardly from the low Appl analysis, where both surface forms are derived from underlying DAT $\gg$ ACC
- In §3.2, I will show that while scope is frozen in the DAT-ACC configuration, reconstructed scope is available in ACC-DAT forms. I contend these facts are, too, compatible with the low Appl proposal

3.1 Variable binding

- The universal quantifier in Latvian is *katrs* ‘every.NOM.FSG’. It agrees in gender, case, and number with its restrictor
- The 3SG possessive forms in Latvian corresponds to the genitive inflection of the corresponding personal pronouns: *viņa* ‘his’, *viņas* ‘her’. They do not agree in gender/number with the possessum.

The pair in (8) shows that, for the DAT-ACC surface configuration, a bound variable reading for *viņas tēvu* ‘her father.ACC’ is only available if it is preceded by the quantified expression *katrai meitenei* ‘every girl.DAT’ (8a).

Conversely, backward binding is not available in (8b): *viņas tēvam* ‘her father.DAT’ can only get a referential reading.

(8) *DAT-ACC: no backward binding*

- a. Es *katrai* *meitenei_i* *parādīju* *viņas_{i/j}* *tēvu* *spoguļi*
 I.NOM every.DAT girl.DAT showed.1SG her father.ACC mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed every girl.DAT her father in the mirror.’
- b. Es *viņas_{*i/j}* *tēvam* *parādīju* *katru* *meiteni_i* *spoguļi*
 I.NOM her father.DAT showed.1SG every.ACC girl.ACC mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed her father.DAT every girl in the mirror.’

Now turning to the ACC-DAT configuration, we get an interesting result: **when the ACC quantified DP precedes the pronoun, the bound variable reading is considerably degraded.** (cf. the fully grammatical (8a).)

Again, backward binding is not available in (9b), *viņas tēvu* ‘her father.ACC’ can only get a refer-

ential reading.

(9) *ACC-DAT: no backward binding*

- a. Es katru meiteni_i parādīju viņas_{??i/j} tēvam spoguļi WCO
 I.NOM every.ACC girl.ACC showed.1SG her father.DAT mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed every girl.ACC to her father in the mirror.’
- b. Es viņas_{*i/j} tēvu parādīju katrai meitenei_i spoguļi
 I.NOM her father.ACC showed.1SG every.DAT girl.DAT mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed her father.ACC to every girl in the mirror.’

If the proposal that the word order in (9) is derived via movement from underlying DAT *gg* ACC, then (9a) looks like a Weak Crossover (WCO) violation! This is sketched out in (10) below:

(10) *Analysis (i): underlying DAT >> ACC*

- ?? Es katru meiteni_i parādīju viņas_i tēvam *t* spoguļi
 ↑
 WCO violation

Let us consider what would be predicted if we assumed, instead, that (9) corresponds to a different, underlying ACC *gg* DAT structure. Under this alternative analysis, (9a) is not predicted to give rise to a WCO violation:

(10') *Analysis (ii): underlying ACC >> DAT*

- ?? Es katru meiteni_i parādīju *t* viņas_i tēvam spoguļi
 ↑
 no WCO violation

Finally, note that the equivalent to (9a), but with a non-quantified expression serving as antecedent, allows for a coreferential reading between the pronoun and either *meiteni* ‘girl.ACC’ (11a) or *Maiju* ‘Mary.ACC’:

(11) *ACC-DAT surface configuration:*

- a. Es meiteni_i parādīju viņas_{i/j} tēvam spoguļi
 I.NOM girl.ACC showed.1SG her father.DAT mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed the girl.ACC to her father in the mirror.’
- b. Es Maiju_i parādīju viņas_{i/j} tēvam spoguļi
 I.NOM Mary.ACC showed.1SG her father.DAT mirror.LOC
 ‘I showed Mary.ACC to her father in the mirror.’

4 Inert Dative

In §4.1, I will present evidence from object asymmetries in passives of ditransitives that support the proposal in (1): namely that the Goal argument is assigned inert Dative case by the low Appl head in Latvian, rendering it inert for further A-operations.

4.1 Passives of ditransitives

Note that only the direct object of a ditransitive can be passivized and marked as nominative in Latvian; the indirect object cannot take NOM in a passive (15c). However, since word order is relatively free, both (15a-b) are possible, where either the NOM or DAT argument occupy the pre-verbal position:

- (15) a. Grāmata tika iedota Reinim
book.NOM was.3 given.3 R.DAT
 ‘A book.NOM was given to Reinis.’
- b. Reinim tika iedota grāmata
R.DAT was.3 given.3 book.NOM
 ‘Reinis.DAT was given a book.NOM.’
- c. *Reinis tika iedota grāmata / grāmatu
R.NOM was.3 given.3 book.NOM / book.ACC
 Intended: ‘Reinis.NOM was given a book.’

We can show that the DAT argument is not the grammatical subject of the passive with a **control test**. In Latvian, only subjects can be controlled by an argument of the main clause. In passives of ditransitives, the DAT argument cannot be controlled:

- (16) *Pēteris_i grib PRO_i tikt iedots grāmata / grāmatu
Peter.NOM want.3 PRO be.INF given.PASS book.NOM / book.ACC
 Intended: ‘Peter wants to be given a book.’

References

- Bruening, Benjamin. 2001. "QR Obeys Superiority: Frozen Scope and ACD." *Linguistic Inquiry* 32 (2): 233–73.
- Kaiser, Elsi. 2000. "A First Look at the Structure of Finnish Ditransitive Verbs." In *Proceedings of the Twelfth Student Conference in Linguistics*, edited by J. Haugen and T. Louthain, 38:111–26. MIT Working Papers in Linguistics. Cambridge, Mass.
- McGinnis, Martha. 1998. "Locality and Inert Case." In *Proceedings of NELS 28*, edited by Pius Tamanji and Kiyomi Kusumoto. Amherst: GLSA.
- McGinnis, Martha. 2008. "Applicatives." *Language and Linguistics Compass* 2 (6): 1225–45.
- Pylkkänen, Liina. 2000. "What Applicative Heads Apply To." *University of Pennsylvania Working Papers in Linguistics* 7 (1): 197–210.
- Pylkkänen, Liina. 2002. "Introducing Arguments." PhD diss., Massachusetts Institute of Technology.